

UNDERNOURISHED Children at an anganwadi in Ahmedabad's Velajpur area

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GUJARAT

A MALNUTRITION BLIGHT

By Jumana Shah

On March 28, a CAG report tabled in the state assembly hit a raw nerve in Gujarat. The report identified a shortage of 16,045 Anganwadi Centres (AWC) in Gujarat, seen against the norms set by the Ministry of Women and Child Development (MoWCD). With a population of 55.3 million, Gujarat must ideally have 69,074 AWCs, but it had only 53,029, as of March 2023. More importantly, the number of children (0-6 years) enrolled in them is a lot less than it should be, even if extrapolated from the 2011 Census data.

The Census suggested that 7.8 million children should be enrolled in AWCs, but the CAG report showed only 4.1 million, indicating a "massive gap"—between 2015-16 and 2022-23, some 3.7 million children (48.1 per cent) had missed out on the supplementary nutritional diet provided at anganwadis. Also, only 18.8 per cent of those in the 3-6 age group were enrolled in the AWCs for preschool education.

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AWCs offer a range of critical services in backward areas of India's rural and urban landscape. This is where children, lactating mothers, pregnant women and adolescent girls get supplementary nutrition; children gain access to key health services like vaccination; and mothers and families get educated on childcare, hygiene and nutrition. For children aged 3-6 years, preschool education is also offered. The anganwadis play a pivotal role in controlling malnutrition and stunting among growing children, so when a report highlights 48.1 per cent of them 'missing', it's shorthand for how poorly Gujarat is doing on a range of social and health indices.